

Get the six-year-old XP up to Vista speed with a few nifty additions!

Rossi Fernandes

It's quite probable that you don't want to move to Vista right now, and that you still have an urge to try some of its features. The whole Vista thing being called the biggest tech failure of 2007 isn't encouraging, either. However, there is hope in the form of standalone add-on programs for XP that can give you close to the entire Vista experience.

Note: A lot of these programs are in development phase, and some of them might modify system files—so proceed with caution.

STEP 1 Using A Sidebar Sidebars may have existed since the early days when details of Vista were being leaked onto the Web.

Sidebars are a great way to have instant access to information such as weather, RSS feeds, and mail all the same time on your Desktop. If you want a sidebar today, you have several good ones to choose from. The most famous has to be Google Desktop (<http://desktop.google.com>). You can download it or free. Once installed, right-click on the icon in the system tray and make sure you set it as a sidebar. Click the + sign at the top of the sidebar to add gadgets to it. You can shift them all about the sidebar by dragging and dropping.

Another software that can be used to install a sidebar is Desktop Sidebar (www.desktopsidebar.com). Desktop sidebar, too, is powerful, but not as attractive or Vista-like looking as Google Desktop. You can always download skins for it, though.

STEP 2 File Indexing And Searching Google Desktop is more than just a sidebar—it is also an indexing tool. These can scan your drive for documents and other files, and locating files becomes much faster than if you were to use the default Windows search. To look for files in Google, press [Ctrl] twice, and a search window will

appear. The text field in the sidebar can also be used.

Another well-known indexing tool is Copernic Desktop Search 2 (www.copernic.com). Like the Google Desktop indexing feature, you can use Copernic Desktop Search to look for files and e-mails. Because the initial indexing is a slow process, it's a good idea to force the indexing process in Copernic Desktop Search whenever you aren't going to be using the computer. Go to Tools > Options > Indexing & Performance. Uncheck two boxes: Suspend indexing while I use my computer, and Suspend indexing while computer resources are highly used.

STEP 3 Taskbar Visual Tips Visual tooltips are small visual previews of windows; they appear when you move your mouse pointer over an item in the taskbar. You can get Visual Tooltip from www.chrisnsoft.com/visual-tooltip/. Unzip the file and run VisualToolTip.exe. Now move the mouse pointer over the taskbar and you'll be able to see previews of programs. You can modify the size of each preview by right-clicking on the system tray icon and then selecting Options. Click the Thumbnail tab. Any other changes to the look of the tooltips can be done by clicking on the Display tab.

STEP 4 Getting The Vista Look XP themes have been around for quite a while, and designers have been working on themes that look a lot like Vista. For custom themes to work on Windows XP, you first need to patch the UXTHEME.DLL file. If you'd like, you can download an automated patcher from www.softpedia.com/progDownload/UXTheme-MultiPatcher-Download-2369.html. Run the patcher and Cancel any warnings about Windows files being replaced. Reboot, and you'll be able to use custom themes. Copy the theme files you download into C:\Windows\Resources\Themes. Double-click the .theme file to preview the theme. In the Display properties window, click on Apply to apply the theme. Sites like www.themexp.org and www.deviantart.com have loads of themes—and quite a few that mimic Vista's default theme.

STEP 5 The Vista Start Menu This is a little different from the one in XP: it has a search bar. Vista Start Menu Emulator (<http://vseproject.extra.hu>) is a little application that brings Vista's Start Menu to XP. If you have a good Vista theme installed, this Start Menu replacement will work as a great combination.

A very good alternative to Vista Start Menu Emulator is called ViStart (<http://lee-soft.com>).

STEP 6 Flipping Windows! Top Desk (www.otakusoftware.com/topdesk/) is a neat little utility that allows you to get the effect Vista gives you when you multitask between applications. After you install Top Desk, pressing [Windows Key] + [Tab] will show you a visual list of all running applications. You can keep pressing the key combo (or use the arrow keys) to switch between applications.



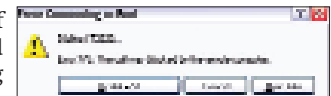
The flip effect from Vista on Windows is possible with Top Desk

STEP 7 Performance Boost ReadyBoost is one of Vista's performance boosting features. ReadyBoost works by using a USB Flash drive as additional memory. For ReadyBoost, you can find a commercial software called eBoostr (www.eboostr.com). Once you have the program installed, reboot the computer. Start the program, and you can now add a Flash drive that you want it to use. Enter the size of the cache file you want to use.

STEP 7 Windows Media Player 11 Every major Windows release is highlighted by the release of a new Windows Media Player. Vista came out with Windows Media Player 11, but Microsoft also has it out for XP. It is available for free download from www.microsoft.com/windows/windowsmedia/player/11/default.aspx ■

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expired. Of course, you could even be dialling the wrong number, but from the screenshot you've sent in, it appears to be correct. So if you're sure about the validity of your details and your account, contact the BSNL Helpdesk.



The BSNL NetOne connection error message

Here's Your Link!

My computer is infected by the Brontok virus; it resides in the My Document and My Pictures folders as an HTML file. I've tried deleting it many times, but it reappears. I've tried to download the removal tool from Softpedia.com, but it does not get downloaded. Please help.

Tushar Dharashive

Download the Brontok virus removal tool from <http://dnl-prl.kaspersky-labs.com/utills/klwk/klwk.zip>. This is a small (70 KB) file and can be easily downloaded. Extract the contents to a folder and run the executable file. Reboot the computer after the removal process is done, and install a good anti-virus software to prevent future infections.

The Way It's Read

Is there a way to make numbers show up with the thousand separator (by default) in Word 2007?

Santosh Bhide

Choose the Insert tab on the Ribbon and select Quick Parts > Field. Select the item =Formula in the list and click Formula. Type your number in the Formula field preceded by the equals symbol. Enter #,##0.00 in the Number format field and click OK. Done!

To make changes to the value, click on the number and press [Shift] + [F9]. This will show the fields so you can change the value. Press [Shift] + [F9] to retain the format—you'll see what we mean when you try it.

A Patch To Match

I want to play *Quake 3 Arena* online, but I'm not able to connect to some servers even though they are listed in the multiplayer option of the game.

Raghav Chari

Verify that you have installed the latest patch for *Quake 3 Arena*; it is 1.32c, available for download from www.idsoftware.com. If, when you click on the server in the list, you see the default *Quake 3* logo, then you do not have the map or mod the server is using, so you won't be able to connect to it. Go to Game Options in the game and set Automatic Downloading to On (this allows you to download the required map automatically). Some game servers require PunkBuster to be installed and enabled, and this is mentioned after the server name in the list. The latest *Quake 3* patch comes with this anti-cheat software, but in case you opted to not install it, you need to do so by downloading it from www.evenbalance.com/index.php?page=pbspsetup.php. (Download the version for your OS.)

You've Got To Tell It!

I recently purchased an NVIDIA 7600GS PCI-Express graphics card, but it doesn't display anything on my ATI RS480 motherboard. The graphics card works when it's installed in my friend's computer. My computer can still boot using the onboard graphics, so my motherboard is not faulty.

Pankaj Thorat

It looks like your motherboard is still using the onboard graphics to boot. You need to set the PCI-Express graphics card to initialise first. Enter the BIOS, look under Integrated Peripherals > Init Display First, and set it to PCIEx.

The Indian Connection

I use Yahoo! Messenger to voice-chat with my friends. I recently purchased a webcam. When I try to chat with the webcam on, the audio quality becomes very poor, and it is often inaudible.

Rajesh D

You need a broadband connection to be able to video-chat; your Internet bandwidth is probably not enough to support video chat—try and see if you can get a faster connection! If you can't, you could reduce the size of the video stream by reducing the resolution of the webcam under the webcam's advanced properties. Also, do not download while chatting; this eats up bandwidth.

Out With The Old

I tried to install Office 2007 from the *Digit* DVD, and it displays an error: "An error occurred during installation and setup was unable to complete." When I clicked on PowerPoint setup, it shows "Error 1731." I have Media Center Edition.

Kiran Kumar Sripati

This error occurs when you try to update, reinstall, or install an additional feature of a Windows Installer setup-based program from a different version of the source setup. In your case, you may have an earlier version of Microsoft Office installed. You need to uninstall that version before trying to install the newer version. You may need the original installation source files of the older version of Office to be able to uninstall it.

Sound Off!

When I try to play a song on my computer, I get this message: "Cannot play back the audio stream: no audio hardware is available, or the hardware is not responding". I use Windows XP.

Sarang Phadnis

This error occurs when the computer does not have an external sound card, when your sound card is not working properly, or when the sound hardware acceleration is set too high. Install the latest drivers for your sound card. Open Sound and Audio Devices in the Control Panel. Click on the Audio tab, then on the Advanced button under Sound Playback. Click on the Performance tab and move the Hardware Acceleration slider a notch closer to None. Click OK, and restart your computer.